MUSKET WARFARE

By 1800, the Maori had begun to have contact with Europeans, as whalers, sealers, and traders stopped off on the New Zealand coast. The Europeans brought with them flintlock muskets, which had an obvious appeal for Maori warriors. Initially, these inherently clumsy and inaccurate firearms had little effect on local warfare. In 1807, when the Nga Puhi tribe first used muskets in battle, they were trounced by their traditionally armed enemies, the Ngati Whatua. Quickly, though, tribes that equipped themselves with muskets began to establish their dominance. A substantial commerce developed in which the Maori exchanged potatoes, pigs, or flax for firearms and ammunition. They soon discovered that the products of war could also be traded for guns, since the Europeans would accept war captives as slaves and the embalmed heads of the slain as curios. Some Maori chiefs travelled to the Australian colonies and at least one, Hongi Hika, visited Britain, where he had an audience with King George IV in 1820. These contacts with the wider world encouraged the territorial ambitions of some Maori leaders, and provided new and improved military technology.

War canoe
Waka taua were the Maori warrior's usual mode of transport. They were as long as 40m (130ft) and could hold up to 70 men. Two canoes were sufficient to transport an entire war party. A bailer *(below)* was essential kit in case the boat took on water.





CANOE BAILER

From the 1810s to the 1830s, the Maori tribes engaged in a series of highly destructive conflicts that have been called the Musket Wars. These conflicts were fought in ways that were broadly similar to traditional Maori warfare, with war parties attacking tribes against whom they had grievances, the enemy dead being eaten, and weaker groups taking refuge in forts. But the scale of the fighting was much greater than before. Led by Hongi Hika, the Nga Puhi sent out musket-armed war parties 800 or 900 strong on long-distance raiding expeditions. Other tribes such as the Ngati Toa, led by Te Rauparaha, imitated their example. Weaker tribes were massacred, enslaved, or driven off their lands. The conflicts petered out in the 1830s, partly because once all Maori had

> "NOT ONE ESCAPED. SOME RAN AWAY FROM US, THESE WE KILLED AND OTHERS WE KILLED – BUT WHAT OF THAT? IT WAS IN ACCORDANCE WITH OUR CUSTOM."
>
> **MAORI WARRIOR** ON MASSACRE OF CHATHAM ISLAND POPULATION, 1835

Tribal gathering
The warrior culture survived long after the pacification of New Zealand in the mid-19th century. This photograph of a meeting of Maori warriors dates from around 1920.

